



It's really important to **take care of yourself** as well as your new baby. Being in labor will leave you exhausted, or you might have had a C-section. Either way, you will need time to recover as well as adapt to your new life. Your body will also undergo an **enormous amount of change** as you return to your pre-pregnant state.

Birth recovery

Physical impact

Whatever type of labor and birth you had, you will be feeling the physical effects. You are likely to be exhausted, especially if you had a long labor. If you tore or had an episiotomy (a cut to the vagina and perineal area), you will be sore from the stitches, which can make sitting uncomfortable and may sting when you urinate. If you had a cesarean section, you will be recovering from major abdominal surgery, which takes several weeks. You will need to take it easy and draw on all the support you can.

Your body has done an amazing job in the past nine months, and now it will begin to return to its pre-pregnancy state, which will involve some dramatic hormonal changes. Your breasts will start to fill with milk to feed your baby.

Emotional roller coaster

Your emotions after birth can swing wildly: one minute you feel intensely happy, imbued with the joy of motherhood as you nestle in with your new baby, but the next moment you may feel anxious and weepy as exhaustion sets in. Hormones play havoc with your emotions, and you may feel an odd sense of emptiness since, bereft of your belly, you have lost the intimacy of carrying your baby around with you. Most women

experience "the baby blues" a few days after the birth. In the middle of this physical and emotional upheaval, you are trying to deal with one of the most important tasks of your life: taking care of your new baby. This is the time to accept all the support you can get. The most significant being from your partner, who is there to hold the helm in the first few days while you recover, and give you the emotional and physical support you need.

Help from family and friends over the coming weeks will make a real and valuable contribution and each gesture will make all the difference—whether it's having meals cooked, ironing done, or simply letting someone take care of your baby for an hour or two while you sleep. Be honest with those close to you about what you need.

Give yourself time

While six weeks is often talked about as the period of time it takes to recover from birth, this figure is somewhat arbitrary. A recent study found that women need a year to recover completely and get back on track after birth, so it's vital to go slowly. Give yourself time to put your feet up, and to concentrate on you: eat well, find ways to relax, and gradually regain your activity levels, eventually returning to a gentle exercise regimen. All of these things will help you to recover well.